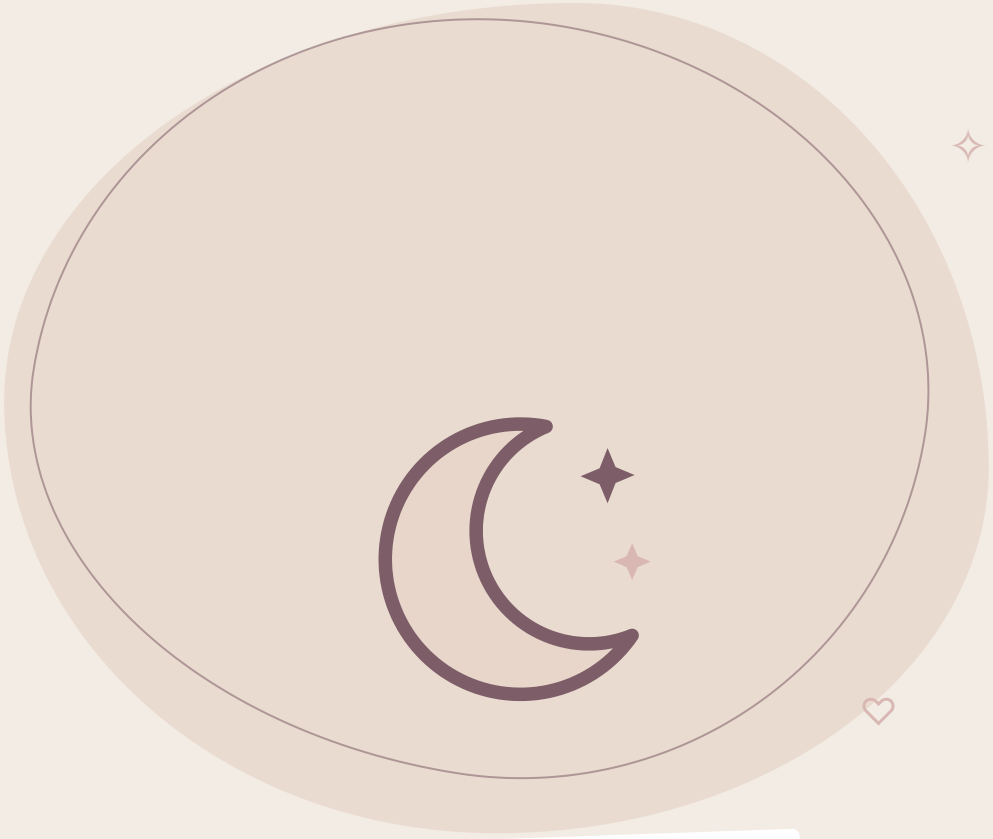
Movecia



MINDFUL MOVEMENT METHOD · MONTH 1

Retreat & Rest

Gathering strength in the dark season

for .....

A LETTER FOR YOU

Hi lovely

Welcome to your first month. Outside it gets dark early, the meadows lie still under the snow, and when I head out to the horses in the morning, the air is so clear and cold that every breath makes a little cloud. At this time of year nature withdraws and gathers strength for the year ahead. That's exactly the movement I'd love to bring onto the mat with you over the coming weeks.

At the same time, I know that for many of us December is anything but quiet. There are Christmas parties at school and nursery, presents, visits, biscuits and a long list of things someone has to remember. Our body feels this contradiction very clearly. It wants to slow down, and we ask it to go faster. Maybe you know the feeling of being tired in the evening and yet too restless to fall asleep.

That's why this month is all about retreat and rest. I invite you to create little islands for yourself where you don't have to achieve anything. We move gently, we build a strength that carries you without wearing you out, and again and again we give your nervous system the chance to settle.

In this workbook you'll find everything that goes with the twelve videos of the month: the science behind Box Breathing, somatics, mental load, gentle strength training and sleep, pages for planning and reflecting, and at the end a little kitchen section with warming recipes that make cooking easier on busy winter days. You don't have to read everything or fill everything in. Take what does you good and leave the rest until you need it.

I'm so glad you're here, and I wish you a calm, warm month. With love, Vivien

♡ Vivien

WHAT'S INSIDE

Retreat & Rest
Why rest is a source of strength and what we can learn from the cycles of nature.

Your video plan
All twelve videos of the month at a glance, ready to tick off.

Your flows and movement videos
What to expect in the movement videos and which exercises they include.

Box Breathing
Four equal counts for full days, with a practice and the background behind it.

Somatic Release
What somatics is and how you learn to read your body's signals.

Mental load
Making the invisible mental work visible, handing it over and talking about it.



Strength Without Exhaustion

Why gentle strength training is so valuable for women.



Evening routine & sleep

Evening anchors, sleep hygiene and your evening meditation.



Your planner

Weekly planner, monthly plan and your self-care list.



Meal prep for calm winter days

A simple plan, a shopping list and six warming recipes.



Your month in review

What has changed and what you'd like to take with you.

THIS MONTH'S THEME

Retreat & Rest

Winter is the season of pausing. This chapter is about why rest isn't wasted time and how you can allow yourself to have it, even when your everyday life is full.

When you walk through a forest in winter, at first glance everything seems still and lifeless. The trees have shed their leaves, the flowers have disappeared, and many animals are resting for the winter. Beneath the surface, though, a great deal is going on. The trees draw their nutrients back into their roots, seeds lie protected in the earth waiting for the right moment, and next spring's leaves are already formed inside the buds. So winter is a phase in which strength is gathered.

We humans are part of this natural world too, even if our everyday lives make it easy to forget. Our body responds to the shorter days, the lack of light and the cold. Many women tell me that in winter they need more sleep, crave warm food more and want to withdraw earlier in the evening. That's completely natural. And yet in December we often live as if it were midsummer, with packed calendars, late nights and few breaks.

Rest as a source of strength

Many of us learned early on that a break has to be earned first. First the kitchen gets tidied, the laundry folded and the email answered, and only then, once everything is done, are we allowed to sit down. The trouble is that the list is never really finished. So we keep postponing the break until we fall into bed exhausted at night.

Yet rest is what makes it possible for us to have strength at all. Muscles grow stronger in the recovery phases after training, our brain sorts through what we've experienced and learned during the day while we sleep, and our nervous system needs calm phases to recover from tension. So when you allow yourself rest, you're gathering energy for everything that comes after.

GOOD TO KNOW

Your nervous system in balance

The autonomic nervous system controls many processes in the body without us having to think about them, such as heartbeat, breathing and digestion. Put simply, there's one branch that activates us and gets us ready to perform, the sympathetic nervous system, and one that supports recovery, digestion and regeneration, the parasympathetic nervous system. Both are important and constantly alternate in a healthy everyday life. It becomes difficult when, over a long period, we hardly ever find our way into recovery. Slow movement, a calm breath with a long exhale and real breaks can help get this alternation going again.

What we can learn from the cycles of nature

In nature, everything has its time. Growth in spring is followed by the abundance of summer, then harvesting and letting go in autumn, and finally rest in winter. No tree blossoms all year round, and nobody would expect it to. Yet that's exactly what we often expect of ourselves: to have the same amount of energy every day and to be equally productive and equally cheerful.

When we see our life as a series of cycles, a lot becomes easier. There are weeks when we get a great deal done and weeks when above all we need to gather strength. As a woman you may also know the cycle within a month, in which energy and mood can shift. And there are phases of life, such as when children are small, when there's less room left for ourselves. None of these phases is better or worse than another. They belong together.

Why breaks are productive

Maybe you've experienced the solution to a problem coming to you precisely when you weren't thinking about it at all, in the shower, on a walk or just before falling asleep. That's no coincidence. When we step away from a task, our brain keeps working in the background and makes new connections between thoughts. Short breaks between focused phases help many people stay more attentive and more relaxed throughout the day.

A break doesn't have to be long. Just a few conscious breaths, a glance out of the window or five minutes in Child's Pose can make a difference. What matters is that you really pause in that moment rather than scrolling through your phone at the same time, because for the brain that's a form of work too.

My tip for you

On full days I've got into the habit of taking a little break exactly when I notice I'm getting impatient. Instead of quickly getting the next thing done, I sit down for two minutes, have a sip of tea and breathe. Afterwards the next thing almost always goes more easily.

What's waiting for you this month

The twelve videos of this month take you from the first calm morning flow all the way to a strengthening movement video for legs and hips at the end. In between you'll find breathing practices for full days, gentle somatics, a conversation about mental load, a strength session that builds you up without draining you, and an evening meditation that helps you put the day down. Each video builds on the one before, and by the end of the month you'll notice how much strength there is in rest.

To begin

How does winter feel in my body? What do I long for at this time of year?

Where in my everyday life do I expect myself to go faster than is good for me?

What could a little island of calm look like in my everyday life?

Even in stillness, something is growing in me.

OVERVIEW

Your video plan

Twelve videos accompany you through this month. Here you can see them at a glance and note down when you did them.

The videos follow a fixed rhythm. After the talking head about the monthly theme, there's always a flow where I guide you with my voice, then a movement video without talking, with a timer and your own music, and after that another talking head with knowledge, a breathing practice or a meditation. The next video opens as soon as you've fully completed the previous one. The idea is about three sessions a week, which lets you move through the month comfortably in around four weeks.

Month 1 · Retreat & Rest

Video	Type	Done on
1 · Retreat & Rest · What this month is about	Talking head · approx. 5 min.	
2 · Morning Flow for Dark Days	Flow · approx. 15 min.	
3 · Warming up	Movement video · approx. 8 min.	
4 · Box Breathing for Full Days	Talking head · breath · approx. 5 min.	
5 · Somatic Release	Flow · approx. 15 min.	
6 · A strong centre	Movement video · approx. 8 min.	
7 · Mental load: what you may put down today	Talking head · approx. 6 min.	
8 · Strength Without Exhaustion	Flow · approx. 30 min.	
9 · Releasing back and shoulders	Movement video · approx. 8 min.	
10 · Evening Meditation: Retreat	Talking head · meditation · approx. 15 min.	
11 · Evening flow: letting go of the heaviness	Flow · approx. 20 min.	
12 · Legs and hips	Movement video · approx. 8 min.	

What your four weeks could look like

A suggestion with three sessions a week

Week	Session 1	Session 2	Session 3
Week 1	What it's about + Morning Flow	Warming up	Box Breathing
Week 2	Somatic Release	A strong centre	Mental load
Week 3	Strength Without Exhaustion	Releasing back and shoulders	Evening Meditation
Week 4	Evening flow: letting go of the heaviness	Legs and hips	Repeat your favourite video

My tip for you

The short talking heads and movement videos combine nicely with the video that follows when you have a bit more time on a given day. The evening meditation and the evening flow are loveliest in the evening, just before you go to bed. So plan them for a day when you have a little peace in the evening.

GOOD TO KNOW

If you take a break

If you're ill for a week or have visitors, your next video simply waits for you. You can never fall behind. Your next month opens on your monthly start date at the earliest, and only once you've completed this month, so you'll never miss out on anything.

MOVEMENT

Your flows and movement videos

This month you'll meet four flows and four movement videos. Here you'll find out what to pay attention to in each and which exercises they include.

Morning Flow for Dark Days

This flow is meant for the mornings when it's still dark outside and your body doesn't really want to get up yet. You can even begin it in bed, or on the mat with a blanket around your shoulders. We start lying down with Pelvic Tilts, Happy Baby (Ananda Balasana) and a Supine Twist (Supta Matsyendrasana), make our way via Cat-Cow, Thread the Needle and Downward-Facing Dog up to standing, and finish with a Roll Up, Arm Circles and Mountain Pose with your hands at your heart. At the end I ask you what you need today, and you take one single word with you into your day.

Warming up

This short movement video gently warms up your body on cold days. It's wonderful for the morning before you leave the house, or as preparation if you'd like to go for a walk afterwards.

- Shaking
- Standing Arm Circles and Hip Circles
- Standing Body Roll
- Standing Roll Down
- Cat-Cow
- Thread the Needle
- Downward-Facing Dog (Adho Mukha Svanasana)
- Low Lunge (Anjaneyasana)
- Squat
- Mountain Pose (Tadasana)

A strong centre

A strong centre means far more than a flat stomach. It's about the interplay of your deep abdominal muscles, back muscles, diaphragm and pelvic floor that supports your spine when you lift a child, carry shopping or sit at a desk for a long time. In this movement video you train this centre in a calm, controlled way.

- Pelvic Tilts
- Glute Bridge
- Dead Bug
- Bird Dog
- Forearm Plank

- Kneeling Side Plank
- Swimming (Pilates) lying on your front
- Toe Taps
- Child's Pose (Balasana)

GOOD TO KNOW

After giving birth

If you've recently had a baby or have diastasis recti, meaning a gap between the two sides of your rectus abdominis, the “six-pack” muscle, please talk to your doctor, midwife or a physiotherapist first. Exercises like the Forearm Plank are often not yet suitable then. In all exercises, make sure your belly doesn't dome forwards and that you don't feel any downward pressure on your pelvic floor.

Releasing back and shoulders

This video is for all the days when you've done a lot of carrying, bending and sitting. It opens your chest, mobilises your upper back and lets your shoulders drop. For the Doorway Chest Stretch and Wall Angels you'll need a door frame and a bit of free wall.

- Cat-Cow
- Thread the Needle
- Open Book (upper-back rotation lying on your side)
- Sphinx (Salamba Bhujangasana)
- Baby Cobra (Bhujangasana)
- Doorway Chest Stretch
- Wall Angels
- Child's Pose (Balasana)
- Supine Twist (Supta Matsyendrasana)

Evening flow: letting go of the heaviness

The evening flow is a calm way to end the day that helps you set down its weight. You begin with your hands on your heart and belly, move your back through Cat-Cow and Thread the Needle, sink into Child's Pose, open your hips in a Supine Figure Four, twist gently in a Supine Twist, rock in Happy Baby and finally rest your legs up the wall (Viparita Karani) before you arrive in final relaxation (Savasana). Keep a blanket ready, because your body cools down quickly at the end.

Legs and hips

To round off the month you get a movement video for strong legs and mobile hips, entirely without hurry.

- Squat
- Reverse Lunge
- Side Lunge
- Calf Raises

- Clamshell
- Side Leg Lift
- Glute Bridge
- Lizard Pose
- Supine Figure Four

My tip for you

In the movement videos you choose yourself whether an exercise lasts 30 or 45 seconds. If you're just starting out, begin with 30 seconds and give yourself a calm breath between exercises. Once that feels easy, try 45 seconds.

My notes on the movement videos

Video	Timer	What felt easy	What was challenging
Warming up			
A strong centre			
Releasing back and shoulders			
Legs and hips			

VIDEO 4

Box Breathing

Box Breathing is a simple breathing technique with four phases of equal length. It helps you find your way back to your centre on full days.

Picture a square with four sides of equal length. You link each side with one phase of your breath: breathe in, hold, breathe out, hold. Each phase lasts the same amount of time, usually four counts. The steady counting gives your mind a clear, simple task, and your breath becomes slower and calmer all by itself.



BREATHWORK

Box Breathing

4 · 4 · 4 · 4

Breathe in through your nose and count to four. Hold your breath gently and count to four. Breathe out slowly and count to four. Hold with empty lungs and count to four. Repeat this for about eight rounds.

How to practise Box Breathing

5 minutes

Sit up tall, place your feet firmly on the floor and rest your hands on your thighs.

1. Breathe out once quite naturally and let your shoulders drop.
2. Breathe in through your nose and slowly count to four. Imagine tracing along the first side of the square.
3. Hold your breath gently, without pressure in your throat, and count to four.
4. Breathe out slowly through your nose and count to four.
5. Keep your lungs empty and count to four again.
6. Repeat this for about eight rounds. Then let go of the counting and keep breathing naturally.
7. Take a moment to notice how your mind and your body feel now.

GOOD TO KNOW

What happens when you breathe evenly

At rest, adults usually breathe about twelve to eighteen times a minute. With Box Breathing at four counts per phase, it's only three to four breaths a minute. Many people experience such a slow, even breath as calming, and early studies on slow breathing suggest it may help reduce tension in the short term. Box Breathing is also an anchor for concentration, because the counting gathers your thoughts for a few minutes.

When Box Breathing can help you

- Before an important conversation, for example with your child's teacher or your boss
- When your head is already full of to-dos in the morning before the day has properly begun
- In the car outside the nursery, before you get out
- When you notice you're about to raise your voice
- Before falling asleep, when your thoughts keep circling
- Before a decision you don't want to make on gut feeling alone

If holding your breath is hard

Some women find holding their breath uncomfortable, especially holding with empty lungs. In that case you can shorten the holds, for example to two counts, or leave them out completely. You can also begin with three counts per side. If you're pregnant, have high blood pressure, a heart or lung condition, or are prone to panic attacks, it's better to skip the holds and simply breathe in and out evenly. If you feel dizzy, stop and go back to breathing normally.

My tip for you

I like to draw the square on my thigh with my index finger while I count. That way I don't need to imagine anything, and nobody notices that I'm doing a breathing practice, not even in a crowded waiting room.

My Box Breathing log

Date	Situation	Rounds	How did I feel afterwards?

VIDEO 5

Somatic Release

Somatics invites you to sense your body from the inside. Instead of copying a shape from the outside, you feel how a movement feels.

The word “soma” comes from Greek and means “body”. In the 1970s the American philosopher and movement educator Thomas Hanna coined the term somatics for methods in which we experience the body as it feels from within. Today the term covers many mindful forms of movement, such as Hanna Somatics, the Feldenkrais Method or certain approaches from dance and bodywork. What they have in common is moving slowly and attentively.

How somatics differs from ordinary exercise

In many forms of training we orient ourselves by an image from the outside. We want to do the pose the way the instructor shows it and pay attention to angles, repetitions and pace. In somatics you turn your attention inwards. You move so slowly that you can feel every little change, and letting go matters just as much as engaging.

GOOD TO KNOW

Engaging in order to let go

Thomas Hanna described how muscles can stay permanently tense through stress and habit without us noticing any more. He called this “sensory-motor amnesia”. In Hanna Somatics, a muscle is therefore first engaged consciously and slowly, and then released even more slowly. This technique is called pandiculation and resembles the luxurious stretch that cats and dogs do all by themselves after waking up. Many people experience a clear sense of spaciousness and lightness afterwards.

The exercises in your video

- Shaking: You shake out first your hands, then your arms, shoulders and legs, until your whole body is moving.
- Noticing: You stand still and sense the tingling and warmth in your body.
- Standing weight shift: You sway gently from one foot to the other.
- Body Tapping: You tap your arms, shoulders, back and legs with loose hands.
- Side contraction lying on your back: You slowly draw the hip and shoulder of one side towards each other and let go even more slowly.
- Pelvic Tilts with a slow release: You gently press your lower back into the floor and release the tension as slowly as you possibly can.
- Head rolls lying on your back: You let your head roll slowly from side to side.
- Final relaxation (Savasana): You let the floor carry you.

GOOD TO KNOW

Why shaking can feel good

Many animals shake their whole body after a frightening situation before returning to their everyday life. The trauma researcher Peter Levine made this observation well known and suggested that people, too, might benefit from such movements. There's still very little research on this. Still, many women find shaking a pleasant way to move tension out of the body, especially after a hectic day.

Learning to read your body's signals

Our body talks to us constantly, it's just that in everyday life we rarely listen. A tight jaw, raised shoulders, shallow breathing or a queasy feeling in the stomach are often early signs that something is weighing on us. The ability to perceive such inner signals is called interoception. It can be practised, and somatics is a wonderful school for it.

The little body check

3 minutes

You can do this check several times a day, sitting, standing or even while cooking.

1. Pause for a moment and close your eyes if you can.
2. Notice your jaw. Are your teeth clenched? Let them part slightly.
3. Notice your shoulders. Have they crept up towards your ears? Let them drop as you breathe out.
4. Notice your belly. Is it tight or soft? Let it expand with your next breath in.
5. Notice your hands. Are they clenched into fists or relaxed?
6. Ask yourself what your body wants to tell you right now, and simply take note of the answer.

My body signals

Signal	When does it show up?	What might it be telling me?	What helps me?
Tight jaw			
Raised shoulders			
Shallow breathing			
Restlessness in my stomach			
Headaches			

My tip for you

If a sound wants to come out of you while you're shaking, a sigh or a hum, just let it come. For me that often helps more than any stretch. If you feel watched while doing it, simply save the practice for when you're home alone.

GOOD TO KNOW

Staying gentle with yourself

Sometimes unexpectedly strong feelings or memories come up during body-based exercises. That's nothing unusual. If it happens, open your eyes, feel your feet on the floor and look around the room. If something weighs heavily on you over a longer period, please seek support from a therapist who can work with you in a safe setting.

After the video

Where in my body did I feel a change after letting go?

Which body signal do I overlook most often in everyday life?

VIDEO 7

Mental load

Mental load is the invisible mental work that's constantly running in the background. In this chapter you make it visible and find ways to hand some of it over.

When you do the laundry, that's a task people can see. The mental load starts much earlier, with knowing that the PE kit has to be dry by Thursday, that the detergent is almost empty and needs to go on the shopping list. Then there's the dentist appointment, the present for a child's birthday party, the message to the teacher and the question of what's for dinner tomorrow. Each of these little things seems harmless on its own. Together they make up a list that's never finished and usually lives in our head.

GOOD TO KNOW

Planning, remembering, keeping track

Research distinguishes between visible housework and the cognitive work behind it: anticipating needs, weighing up options, making decisions and checking that everything has been done. Studies show that in many families this thinking work falls mostly to women, even when both partners work and the visible tasks appear to be shared fairly evenly. Because it's invisible, it's rarely acknowledged.

Why your body feels the mental load

Our nervous system doesn't distinguish very precisely between real danger and a long list of open tasks. Everything that's unfinished can keep us in a state of mild alert. Our shoulders creep up, our breath becomes shallow, our jaw tightens, and in the evening we're tired and yet too restless to fall asleep easily. That's not a sign of weakness. Your body is responding sensibly to a load that has been resting on it for too long.

Step 1 · Your mental load inventory

Before you can hand anything over, you need to see everything you're actually carrying. In the table, write down which tasks come up in your everyday life, who thinks of them, who does them and whether you could imagine handing them over. The first rows are examples that you can overwrite or add to.

My mental load inventory

Task	Who thinks of it?	Who does it?	Could I hand it over?
Booking the children's doctor appointments			
Buying birthday presents			
Planning the week's meals and shopping			
Keeping track of parents' evenings and school messages			
Getting clothes in the right size			
Coordinating family appointments and visits			
Restocking household supplies			

Step 2 · The brain dump



Everything out of your head and onto paper

10 minutes

You'll know this practice from the video. It's best done in the evening, when the day is winding down.

1. Take a blank sheet of paper or the notes page at the end of this chapter.
2. Write down everything buzzing around in your head, the big things as well as the small ones, in no particular order and without judging.
3. Keep writing until nothing else comes to mind. You don't have to get any of it done today.
4. Then mark the things that really matter in the next three days.
5. Cross out everything that isn't actually necessary.
6. Highlight the things someone else could take on.

Step 3 · Really handing it over

When you hand over a task, hand it over with everything that belongs to it, including the remembering. That's often the hardest part, because we're used to still keeping one eye on it in the background. So whoever takes over the children's dentist appointments checks for themselves when the next check-up is

due, calls, puts the appointment in the calendar and goes. It also means it might be done differently from how you'd do it, and that you can let that be.

- Hand over whole areas of responsibility rather than individual chores, for example everything to do with the children's sports and clubs.
- Agree on what the result should be, and leave open how it gets achieved.
- Older children can take responsibility for their own things, such as packing their sports kit or getting their lunchbox ready.
- Some things can simply be dropped. Maybe this year it doesn't have to be five kinds of Christmas biscuits.
- A shared digital shopping list or family calendar takes weight off, as long as everyone uses it.

Step 4 · Talking about it

Mental load can rarely be solved on your own. A calm conversation with your partner can change a lot if it's well prepared. This guide will help you.

1. Find a quiet moment when you're both relaxed, and avoid conversations in passing or in the middle of an argument.
2. Start with your own experience and speak in the first person, for example: “I notice my mind doesn't settle in the evening because I'm thinking about so many things.”
3. Show your inventory. Many partners are genuinely surprised by how many invisible tasks there are.
4. Talk about which tasks matter to both of you and which ones could perhaps be dropped.
5. Divide whole areas with full responsibility, including the planning and the remembering.
6. Agree on a date two to four weeks from now when you'll look at how it's going and adjust.

My tip for you

A fifteen-minute family check-in on Sunday evening can work wonders. Together you look at the coming week, who has which appointments and who's taking care of what. That way a lot moves out of your head and into a shared plan.

The transition pause

Before you switch from one task to the next, say from cooking to homework or from your laptop to the car, take three conscious breaths. Feel your feet on the floor, breathe in through your nose and let the breath flow out slowly and a little longer. Three breaths take maybe fifteen seconds and give your nervous system a small signal that one thing is finished before the next begins.

Your journal question from the video

What am I carrying right now that isn't really mine?

Which one thing will I hand over this week, and to whom?

What can simply be dropped this winter?



My brain dump

GOOD TO KNOW

When it gets too much

If for weeks you've felt exhausted, irritable or empty, are sleeping badly and hardly feel any joy any more, that's a signal that deserves to be taken seriously. Talk to your GP or seek support from a psychotherapist or a counselling service. Doing so is a sign of strength and of caring for yourself.

VIDEO 8

Strength Without Exhaustion

For many women, strength training sounds like heavy weights and sore muscles. In the Method it's about a strength that carries you through everyday life and doesn't drain you.

In your flow “Strength Without Exhaustion” you train for around thirty minutes with your own body weight. You begin with Box Breathing, mobilise your body with Arm Circles, Hip Circles, a Roll Down, Cat-Cow and Downward-Facing Dog, and then work with Squats, Reverse Lunges, Wall or Knee Push-Ups, Glute Bridges, Dead Bug and the Forearm Plank. To wind down you sink into Child's Pose and Reclined Pigeon and arrive in final relaxation.

Why muscles matter so much for women

Our muscles move us, and they do so much more besides. They support our joints and spine, they help prevent falls, and they're an active organ that plays an important role in metabolism. From around the age of thirty, muscle mass slowly begins to decline without training, and over the years this process can speed up. Regular strength training counteracts it, at any age. Even if you start at sixty or seventy, you can still build strength.

GOOD TO KNOW

What the guidelines say

Alongside aerobic activity, the World Health Organization recommends that adults do muscle-strengthening exercises involving all major muscle groups on at least two days a week. That doesn't have to happen at the gym. Bodyweight exercises such as Squats, Lunges, Wall Push-Ups and Glute Bridges count too.

Bones need load

Our bones are living tissue that renews itself throughout our lives. They respond to load: when muscles pull on them and we carry our own weight, they get the stimulus to stay strong. In women, bone density usually peaks around the age of thirty. In the years around menopause, oestrogen levels fall, and because oestrogen is involved in bone metabolism, bone density often declines faster during this time. Strength training and weight-bearing movement such as walking or climbing stairs can help support your bones.

GOOD TO KNOW

Hormones and training

Hormones influence how we feel over the course of a month and over the course of our lives, and movement in turn can affect our wellbeing. Many women find that regular, moderate strength training improves their mood, their sleep and how they feel in their body, including during menopause. How strong such effects are varies greatly from person to person. If you have questions about your hormones, bone density or menopause, your gynaecologist is the right person to ask.

Why gentle sometimes makes you stronger

Many women believe a workout only counts if they're completely exhausted afterwards. For muscles and bones, though, what matters most is that they're challenged regularly and get enough time to recover. Especially in a phase of life with little sleep and a lot of responsibility, very hard training can mean extra stress. A calm strength session where you keep your breath and feel awake rather than drained afterwards is something you can keep up for months and years, and that's exactly where its power lies.

- Slow, controlled repetitions often challenge your muscles more than fast ones.
- Breathe out during the effort, for example as you come up out of a squat.
- Stop two to three repetitions before the point where nothing more is possible.
- Choose the easier variation when your technique starts to slip.
- Give your muscles at least one day off between two strength sessions.
- Enough sleep, water and protein from your diet support recovery.

My strength notes

Exercise	Variation	Repetitions	How it felt
Squat			
Reverse Lunge			
Wall Push-Up or Knee Push-Up			
Glute Bridge			
Dead Bug			
Forearm Plank			

My tip for you

The first time, write down which variation you chose and how many repetitions felt good. When you repeat the flow a few weeks later, you'll be amazed at what has changed. A little note like that motivates me more than any bathroom scale.

GOOD TO KNOW

Please look after yourself

If you're pregnant, have just given birth, or have osteoporosis, joint or back problems or a cardiovascular condition, talk to your doctor or physiotherapist before doing strength training. Stop immediately if you feel pain, dizziness or shortness of breath.

My strength can be quiet and still carry me.

VIDEOS 10 AND 11

Evening routine & sleep

The evening often decides how we sleep. This chapter is about small anchors that show your body the day is coming to an end.

Many women tell me that the evening is the only time they finally get to do something for themselves. The children are asleep, the house is quiet, and then they sit on the sofa with their phone for ages, even though they're actually dead tired. That's understandable, because we long for time that belongs only to us. At the same time, we miss that sleep the next morning. A calm evening routine can bring both together: it gives you time for yourself and at the same time prepares you for restful sleep.

GOOD TO KNOW

How sleep is regulated

Our sleep is regulated mainly by two processes. One is sleep pressure, which builds up over the day the longer we're awake. The other is our internal clock, which takes its cues from light. When it gets dark in the evening, the body releases more of the hormone melatonin, which prepares us for the night. Bright light in the evening, especially bluish light from screens, can delay this process. Daylight in the morning, on the other hand, helps set the internal clock. Seven to nine hours of sleep are usually recommended for adults, although individual needs vary.

Evening anchors

Evening anchors are small actions you repeat every evening in the same order. Over time your body links them with going to bed, and even the first ritual signals that it can slowly wind down. Choose two or three that suit you.

- About an hour before bed, dim the lights and switch on warm lamps instead of the ceiling light
- Charge your phone in a set place outside the bedroom
- Drink a cup of herbal tea or golden milk
- Spend five minutes on the evening flow or a few poses from it
- Rest your legs up the wall while breathing calmly
- Write down three good things from the day
- Take a warm shower or a foot bath
- Read a few pages of a paper book
- Listen to the evening meditation in bed

Sleep hygiene in winter

Good sleep starts during the day

- [ ] At least fifteen minutes of daylight in the morning, even when it's cloudy
- [ ] Get up at roughly the same time, even at weekends
- [ ] Avoid caffeine after early afternoon
- [ ] Have your last big meal two to three hours before bed
- [ ] Keep alcohol in the evening moderate, as it can disturb sleep in the second half of the night
- [ ] Keep the bedroom cool, around 16 to 19°C, and air it briefly before bed
- [ ] Make the bedroom as dark and quiet as possible
- [ ] Warm socks if your feet are cold
- [ ] Use your bed only for sleeping and relaxing, and keep work and laptop out

My tip for you

When I wake up at night and my thoughts start circling, there's a little notepad next to my bed. I write down what's going through my head and tell myself it's safely kept there until morning. Then I do a few rounds of the extended exhale, breathing in for four counts and out for six.

Your evening meditation

The evening meditation “Retreat” lasts about fifteen minutes and is meant for listening to in bed or on the sofa under a blanket. It begins with an extended exhale, guides you slowly through your body in a body scan from your feet up to your forehead, and then invites you to set down one thing from today like a coat you take off in the evening. If you fall asleep along the way, that's exactly right.

Setting down the day

5 minutes

A short version of the meditation for evenings when you only have a little time.

1. Lie down comfortably, cover yourself and switch off the light.
2. Breathe in through your nose for four counts and slowly out for six. Repeat this five times.
3. Move your attention from your feet up through your legs, pelvis and belly to your shoulders, and let each area grow heavy.
4. Soften your jaw and smooth your forehead.
5. Think of one thing from today that you don't want to take into the night. Imagine placing it next to your bed.
6. Simply stay lying there and keep breathing calmly.

The evening flow

The evening flow “Letting go of the heaviness” also works well as part of your evening routine. If the twenty minutes feel too long on some evenings, choose two or three poses that do you particular good, such as Child's Pose, Supine Figure Four and Legs Up the Wall, and stay in each for five to ten breaths.

My sleep diary

Date	In bed at	Got up at	Evening anchor	Sleep quality (1 to 10)



My evening

What most often keeps me from going to bed on time in the evening?

What would my ideal evening routine look like, and how much of it is really doable on an ordinary evening?

GOOD TO KNOW

If your sleep stays poor

If for several weeks you've had trouble falling asleep, often lie awake for long stretches at night or feel constantly exhausted despite getting enough sleep, please talk to your doctor. Sleep problems can also have physical causes, such as hormonal changes, and there's good help available that goes beyond an evening routine.



PLANNER

Your planner

On the following pages you'll find a monthly plan, four weekly planners and your self-care list. They help you plan time for yourself as a matter of course.

In winter, a plan is something comforting. It takes decisions off your plate, gives you an overview and shows you where there's still room for rest. At the start of each week, first put in your three Method sessions and your self-care, before the calendar fills up with everything else. That way what does you good gets a fixed place.

My monthly plan

Week	Important appointments	My Method sessions	My island of calm
Week 1			
Week 2			
Week 3			
Week 4			
Week 5			



My focus for this month

What do I want to consciously do without this month?

What do I want to treat myself to this month?

My winter self-care list

- [ ] A walk in daylight, even when it's cold
- [ ] A cup of tea in peace, without my phone
- [ ] A warm bath or foot bath
- [ ] Going to bed earlier than usual
- [ ] Calling a friend who's good for me
- [ ] Lighting a candle and doing nothing for five minutes
- [ ] Reading a book, just for pleasure
- [ ] Making something with my hands, such as knitting, baking or pottery
- [ ] Listening to music that makes me happy
- [ ] Cancelling plans when I need rest
- [ ] Planning an afternoon with no appointments
- [ ] Saying something kind to myself when I'm tired

My tip for you

Stick the self-care list on the fridge or take a photo of it with your phone. On a tired afternoon when you don't know what might do you good, simply pick something from it without thinking too long.



PLANNER

Weekly planner · Week 1

Mon

Tue

Wed

Thu

Fri

Sat

Sun

MY TOP THREE PRIORITIES

SOMETHING JUST FOR ME



PLANNER

Weekly planner · Week 2

Mon

Tue

Wed

Thu

Fri

Sat

Sun

MY TOP THREE PRIORITIES

SOMETHING JUST FOR ME



PLANNER

Weekly planner · Week 3

Mon

Tue

Wed

Thu

Fri

Sat

Sun

MY TOP THREE PRIORITIES

SOMETHING JUST FOR ME



PLANNER

Weekly planner · Week 4

Mon

Tue

Wed

Thu

Fri

Sat

Sun

MY TOP THREE PRIORITIES

SOMETHING JUST FOR ME

My winter tracker

	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
A video from the Method	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
Daylight in the morning	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
Breathing practice	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
A warm, home-cooked meal	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
Phone away an hour before bed	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
Evening anchor	○	○	○	○	○	○	○
Handed something over or let something go	○	○	○	○	○	○	○



KITCHEN

Meal prep for calm winter days

When everyone is hungry at half past five and you still have no idea what to make, cooking can become a burden. A little preparation at the weekend gives you time and calm during the week.

Meal prep simply means planning and preparing some of your meals in advance. It isn't about perfectly portioned containers or a diet. This chapter is about warm, simple food made from seasonal ingredients that fills up the whole family and takes the daily question “What shall I cook today?” off your hands. We're not counting calories here, and no recipe promises any particular effect on your health. It's meant to taste good, warm you up and make your life a little easier.

Three principles

- Simple: Few ingredients, few steps, one pot or one tray whenever possible.
- Seasonal: In winter there are root vegetables, squash, cabbage, leeks, apples and pulses, which keep well and are inexpensive.
- Lightening the load: You cook once and eat twice, or you prepare building blocks that quickly become a meal during the week.



GOOD TO KNOW

Planning saves thinking work

For many women, the question of what to have for dinner is one of the most stubborn parts of the mental load. If you make a rough plan at the weekend and do one big shop, you have far fewer decisions to make during the week. That saves time, trips and money, and often helps you throw away less food as well.

Your meal prep plan

This plan is a suggestion for one week using the six recipes from the next chapter. You'll need about one and a half to two hours on Sunday, during which a lot simmers or roasts away on its own. During the week, each meal then only takes ten to twenty minutes.

Meal prep plan for a winter week

When	What you prepare	What for
Saturday evening	Soak the pearl barley in cold water	Vegetable and barley soup
Sunday	Cook a double batch of vegetable and barley soup, freeze half	Sunday evening and a reserve for later
Sunday	Cook the baked apple compote and spoon it into a jar	Overnight oats for the week
Sunday	Peel and chop the root vegetables and store them in a container in the fridge	Roasted vegetables on Tuesday
Sunday	Stir together the yoghurt tahini sauce	Roasted vegetables on Tuesday
Sunday	Prepare onions, garlic and ginger for two dishes	Lentil and coconut soup and squash dal
Monday	Cook the lentil and coconut soup, keep the rest for Tuesday's lunch	Monday evening
Tuesday	Put the roasted vegetables and chickpeas on the tray	Tuesday evening
Wednesday evening	Set up overnight oats for Thursday and Friday	Breakfast
Thursday	Cook the squash dal with rice, freeze the rest	Thursday evening
Friday	Leftovers night or reheat the frozen soup	A night off from the kitchen
Every evening	Golden milk as an evening anchor	To round off the day

My tip for you

I almost always cook soups and stews in a double batch and freeze half in jars. On the days when everything is too much, I'm grateful for it every single time. Label the jars with what's inside and the date, and you'll still know weeks later what you've got.

Your shopping list

Vegetables and fruit

- [ ] 1 small Hokkaido (red kuri) squash (about 800 g)
- [ ] 800 g root vegetables, for example carrots, parsnips and sweet potato
- [ ] 4 more carrots
- [ ] 1 leek
- [ ] 1 piece of celeriac (about 150 g)
- [ ] 2 medium potatoes
- [ ] 4 onions and 1 red onion
- [ ] 1 bulb of garlic
- [ ] 1 piece of fresh ginger (about 6 cm)
- [ ] 100 g baby spinach
- [ ] 3 apples
- [ ] 1 lemon and 1 lime
- [ ] Fresh parsley and chives

Store cupboard

- [ ] 450 g red lentils
- [ ] 150 g pearl barley
- [ ] 2 tins of chickpeas (400 g each)
- [ ] 2 tins of chopped tomatoes (400 g each)
- [ ] 2 tins of coconut milk (400 ml each)
- [ ] 300 g basmati rice
- [ ] 200 g fine rolled oats
- [ ] 30 g raisins and 40 g walnuts
- [ ] Vegetable stock for about 3 litres
- [ ] Tahini (sesame paste)
- [ ] Maple syrup or honey
- [ ] Olive oil and neutral vegetable oil
- [ ] Spices: cumin, sweet paprika, mild curry powder, turmeric, garam masala, cinnamon, bay leaves, salt, pepper

Chilled

- [ ] 450 g natural yoghurt
- [ ] 1.5 l milk or oat drink
- [ ] Butter
- [ ] Optional: 100 ml whipping cream for the barley soup

My own weekly plan

Day	Breakfast	Lunch	Dinner	Prep
Monday				
Tuesday				
Wednesday				
Thursday				
Friday				
Saturday				
Sunday				

KITCHEN

Six warming recipes

These recipes are simple, seasonal and made for four people. They're easy to prepare ahead and still taste wonderful reheated.

Roasted vegetables with chickpeas and yoghurt tahini sauce

15 minutes prep, 40 minutes in the oven · Serves: 4 people

INGREDIENTS

- 800 g root vegetables, for example carrots, parsnips and sweet potato
- 1 red onion
- 2 tins of chickpeas (400 g each), drained
- 3 tbsp olive oil
- 1 tsp cumin
- 1 tsp sweet paprika
- Salt and pepper
- For the sauce: 250 g natural yoghurt, 2 tbsp tahini, juice of half a lemon, 1 small garlic clove, salt
- A little fresh parsley to sprinkle

METHOD

1. Preheat the oven to 200°C (conventional top and bottom heat, not fan) and line a baking tray with baking paper.
2. Peel the vegetables and cut them into roughly even pieces of two to three centimetres. Cut the onion into wedges.
3. Pat the chickpeas dry with a tea towel so they turn nice and crispy in the oven.
4. Toss the vegetables, onion and chickpeas on the tray with the olive oil, cumin, paprika, salt and pepper.
5. Roast everything for 35 to 40 minutes until the vegetables are soft and lightly browned at the edges. Turn them once halfway through.
6. Meanwhile, stir together the yoghurt, tahini, lemon juice and the finely grated garlic clove and season the sauce with salt.
7. Divide the vegetables between plates, add a generous dollop of sauce on top and sprinkle everything with parsley.

The chopped vegetables keep for two to three days in a container in the fridge, the sauce for about three days. Flatbread or couscous go well with it.

Lentil and coconut soup

30 minutes · Serves: 4 people

INGREDIENTS

- 250 g red lentils
- 1 onion
- 2 garlic cloves
- 1 piece of ginger (about 2 cm)
- 2 carrots
- 1 tbsp neutral vegetable oil
- 1 tbsp mild curry powder
- 1 tin of chopped tomatoes (400 g)
- 1 tin of coconut milk (400 ml)
- 800 ml vegetable stock
- Juice of half a lime
- Salt and pepper
- Fresh parsley or coriander to sprinkle

METHOD

1. Rinse the lentils in a sieve under cold water until the water runs clear.
2. Finely dice the onion, garlic and ginger and cut the carrots into small cubes.
3. Heat the oil in a large pot and gently fry the onion, garlic and ginger for about three minutes until translucent.
4. Add the curry powder and toast it for half a minute, stirring, until fragrant.
5. Add the carrots, lentils, tomatoes, coconut milk and stock and bring everything to the boil.
6. Let the soup simmer over a low heat for about 20 minutes until the lentils are completely soft. Stir now and then.
7. Blend the soup completely or only partly, as you like, and season it with lime juice, salt and pepper.

The soup thickens as it stands. When reheating, simply add a little water or stock. It keeps in the fridge for three days and freezes well.

Overnight oats with baked apple

20 minutes plus a night in the fridge · Serves: 4 people

INGREDIENTS

- 200 g fine rolled oats
- 500 ml milk or oat drink
- 200 g natural yoghurt
- 1 tbsp maple syrup or honey
- a pinch of salt
- For the baked apple: 3 apples, 1 tbsp butter, 1 tsp cinnamon, 30 g raisins, 1 tbsp maple syrup
- 40 g walnuts, roughly chopped

METHOD

1. Stir together the oats, milk, yoghurt, maple syrup and salt in a bowl and divide the mixture between four jars.
2. Cover the jars and put them in the fridge overnight.
3. Peel the apples, remove the cores and cut them into small cubes.
4. Melt the butter in a frying pan and fry the apple cubes over a medium heat for about five minutes.
5. Add the cinnamon, raisins and maple syrup and let everything braise gently for another five minutes until the apples are soft.
6. Briefly toast the walnuts in a dry pan until fragrant.
7. In the morning, top the oats with the baked apple and walnuts. If you like it warm, heat the compote briefly.

The baked apple compote keeps for about four days in a clean jar in the fridge. The oats taste best on the first and second day.

Squash dal with rice

40 minutes · Serves: 4 people

INGREDIENTS

- 1 small Hokkaido (red kuri) squash (about 800 g)
- 200 g red lentils
- 1 onion
- 2 garlic cloves
- 1 piece of ginger (about 2 cm)
- 2 tbsp neutral vegetable oil or butter
- 1 tsp cumin
- 1 tsp turmeric
- 1 tsp garam masala
- 1 tin of chopped tomatoes (400 g)
- 600 ml vegetable stock
- 200 ml coconut milk
- 100 g baby spinach
- Salt and the juice of half a lemon
- 300 g basmati rice

METHOD

1. Wash the squash, cut it in half, remove the seeds and cut it into cubes of about two centimetres with the skin on. Hokkaido skin turns soft as it cooks.
2. Rinse the lentils thoroughly in a sieve. Finely dice the onion, garlic and ginger.
3. Heat the oil or butter in a large pot and gently fry the onion, garlic and ginger. Add the spices and toast them briefly.
4. Add the squash, lentils, tomatoes and stock, bring everything to the boil and let it simmer over a low heat for about 20 minutes.
5. Meanwhile, cook the rice according to the packet instructions.
6. Stir the coconut milk and spinach into the dal and let it sit for another two to three minutes until the spinach has wilted.
7. Season the dal with salt and lemon juice and serve it with the rice.

For children you can keep the dal mild, and adults can add a little chilli at the table. Without the rice, it freezes well.

Vegetable and barley soup

15 minutes prep, 60 minutes cooking · Serves: 4 people

INGREDIENTS

- 150 g pearl barley, soaked the evening before
- 1 onion
- 2 carrots
- 1 piece of celeriac (about 150 g)
- 1 leek
- 2 medium potatoes
- 1 tbsp butter
- 1.5 l vegetable stock
- 1 bay leaf
- Salt and pepper
- Optional: 100 ml whipping cream
- Fresh parsley and chives

METHOD

1. Pour the soaked barley into a sieve and rinse it.
2. Dice the onion, carrots, celeriac and potatoes small and slice the leek into fine rings.
3. Melt the butter in a large pot and gently fry the onion, carrots and celeriac for about five minutes.
4. Add the barley, stock and bay leaf, bring everything to the boil and let the soup simmer, covered, over a low heat for about 40 minutes.
5. Add the potatoes and leek and cook the soup for another 20 minutes until the barley and vegetables are soft.
6. Remove the bay leaf, stir in the cream if you like and season with salt and pepper.
7. Sprinkle the soup with parsley and chives before serving.

This soup is inspired by Tyrolean barley soup, which is traditionally often cooked with smoked pork. If you like, add a piece of smoked meat to the pot. It's even better on the second day and freezes well.

Golden milk

10 minutes · Serves: 4 cups

INGREDIENTS

- 1 l milk or oat drink
- 2 tsp ground turmeric
- 1 tsp cinnamon
- 1 piece of fresh ginger (about 2 cm) or ½ tsp ground ginger
- a pinch of black pepper
- 2 tbsp honey or maple syrup
- Optional: 1 tsp coconut oil or butter

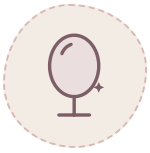
METHOD

1. Peel the ginger and cut it into thin slices.
2. Put the milk, turmeric, cinnamon, ginger, pepper and, if you like, the coconut oil in a pan and whisk everything together.
3. Heat the milk slowly without letting it boil, and let it steep gently for about five minutes.
4. Pour the milk through a fine sieve to remove the ginger slices.
5. Only now sweeten it with honey or maple syrup and, if you like, briefly whisk it until frothy.

Turmeric stains strongly. It's best to use a light-coloured pan and rinse it straight away. Honey isn't suitable for babies under one year old, so simply leave it out for them.

My favourite recipes

Recipe	Who enjoyed it?	What I'll change next time



REVIEW

Your month in review

A month of retreat and rest lies behind you. Take time to look back before you move into your next month.

Find a quiet moment for this review, perhaps with a cup of golden milk and a candle. Beforehand, leaf through this workbook and your notes once more. Often it's only in hindsight that we see how much has happened in a month, even if it didn't feel that way in everyday life. If you like, compare your scores with your check-in from the Arrive workbook too.

How I'm doing at the end of the month

	barely								very
My energy in everyday life	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
How restful my sleep is	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
How calm I feel inside	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
How comfortable I feel in my body	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
How strong I feel	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
How easy I find it to take breaks	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
How well I notice my body's signals	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
How much mental load I'm carrying right now	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10

My review

Which video did me the most good this month, and why?

What has changed in my body or in my everyday life?

Which breathing practice or ritual do I want to keep with me?

What have I handed over or let go of, and how does that feel?

What am I grateful to myself for this month?

What do I wish for my next month?

What I'm taking with me

What I'll keep doing	What I'm letting go of	What I'll try next

A letter to myself for next winter

I have gathered strength, and it stays with me.



Thank you for taking time for yourself this month. The calm you've gathered over these weeks will carry you onwards, and I'm already looking forward to walking with you into your next month.

♡ Vivien